THE RADICAL SHADOW



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- **Sukhbir Singh Badal's religious censure reflects broader efforts to hold the Badal family accountable for perceived undermining of Sikh institutions and panthic politics**
- **The Sikh clergy has intensified actions aligning with radical demands, such as revoking the late Parkash Singh Badal's honorary title (*Panth Rattan Faqr-e-Quam*) and withdrawing privileges of former Akal Takht *jathedar* Gurbachan Singh**
- **Satwant Kaur, daughter of Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale's close aide Amrik Singh, has been named as a part of the committee constituted by the clergy to oversee membership drive and fresh elections after Sukhbir's resignation from SAD chief's post**
- **Moreover, the attack on Sukhbir by a former Khalistani terrorist underscores the agenda of radical elements to erase moderate influence in Punjab's Sikh politics**

PLOT THICKENS
The shooter being overpowered after he opened fire on Sukhbir Badal at the Golden Temple complex, Dec. 4

misconduct—handed down to him just two days before. Folded hands, ashen face, teary eyes...Sukhbir was the picture of penitence as he stood before the Akal Takht, the highest seat of the Sikh faith, to accept his punishment. Alongside him were other senior Akali leaders—a mix of loyalists and rebels—facing similar fates for either complicity or silence in the face of events that shook the Sikh community during the SAD's 2007-17 regime. Their collective transgressions included orchestrating a religious pardon for controversial sect leader Gurmeet Ram Rahim in a blasphemy case, mishandling the 2015 sacrilege incidents and endorsing the actions of "encounter specialist" cops. As penance, the *tankhaiya* leaders were instructed to undertake acts of *sewa*—cleaning shoes, scrubbing toilets and standing guard at five prominent gurdwaras in Punjab.

Sukhbir, once the undisputed protagonist of panthic politics, had long been accused by rivals of undermining Sikh institutions during his heyday. Since 2007, when his father Parkash Singh Badal returned as chief minister, Sukhbir had been the de facto power centre, silencing dissenters and demanding unquestioning loyalty. Holding the charge of both deputy CM and SAD president, his influence even extended to religious affairs like the selection of high priests. Panthic leaders queued at his doorstep for nominations to the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee—or SGPC, the apex body managing Sikh shrines—and it was widely rumoured that his sphere of influence even extended to Giani Gurbachan Singh, then *jathedar* (or head) of the Akal Takht.

The Sikh clergy were therefore seeking to meet a dual challenge in pronouncing the punishment: restoring the credibility of their own institutions while also addressing the decline of the Akali Dal, which had seen its voter base erode in recent years. For over a decade, radicals within the Sikh community had been demanding accountability from the Badals, and while this punishment offered some solace, critics dismissed it as lenient. Many argued that the clergy stopped short of imposing political consequences on Sukhbir and the Akali leadership. However, the public acknowledgment of his missteps—coaxed by Akal Takht *jathedar* Giani Raghubir Singh—did pose a further risk to Sukhbir's already fragile political fortunes. The Sikh clergy even directed the SAD's working committee to accept his resignation from the president's post, which he had tendered amid mounting pressure on November 16. The *jathedar* went so far as to suggest that the current Akali leadership had lost its legitimacy, calling for a complete overhaul. A committee was formed to oversee this

THE ASSASSINATION BID IS A STARK REMINDER OF THE VOLATILE FORCES AT PLAY AS SUKHBIR AND THE AKALI DAL NAVIGATE A PRECARIOUS CROSSROADS BETWEEN REINVENTION AND IRRELEVANCE